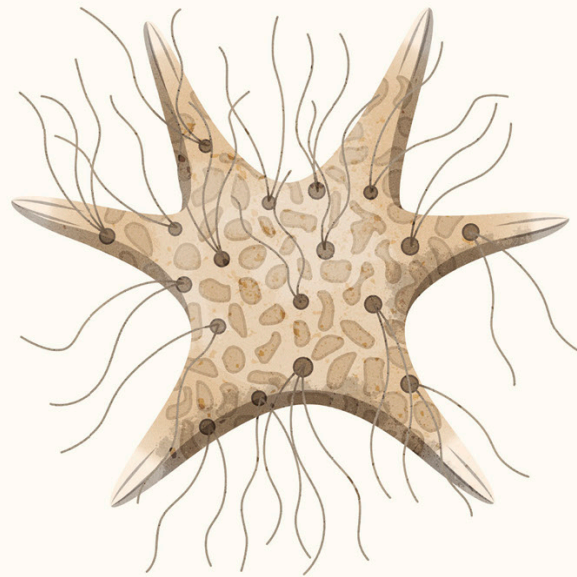


Star sand

Could it be popcorn? Or breakfast cereal maybe? No, it is actually handfuls of star sand. This is not real sand, but the empty shells of miniature creatures known as forams. Each has a sand-sized skeleton made of chalk, some of which are star-shaped. Forams live on the ocean floor, pushing little arms out of holes in their shell to grab mini-meals of bacteria or algae.

When forams die, their shells pile up on the seafloor, and over millions of years turn into rock. Sometimes we find these shells in rocks far from the coast. This is a clue that long ago the area was probably under the ocean.



*There are whole beaches of star sand.
Some are bright pink!*

Japanese star sand,
Western Pacific Ocean